

Andre — Mandarin Teaching Reference Guide

One-to-one online lessons · Teacher reference · Textbook: *HSK Standard Course* (ed. Jiang Liping), Book 3

1. Student Profile

Andre is an adult learner and a native speaker of English. He is highly self-disciplined and a strong independent learner: review and homework outside class are reliably done, so lesson time can be spent almost entirely on speaking and listening.

He is working through the *HSK Standard Course*: Books 1 and 2 are finished, and in Book 3 he has completed Lessons 1–3 and is now continuing from Lesson 4 (Lesson 4: 又...又..., V着V, 了 marking change, 越来越...; Lesson 5: potential complement, 刚 / 刚才). On vocabulary, HSK 1–2 is very secure and HSK 3 is partly acquired, so **please keep example sentences within HSK 1–3 vocabulary as far as possible** — that way he understands and imitates them immediately, and can reuse them himself. His goal is to improve speaking and listening, concentrating on the grammar points below. He has said explicitly that he welcomes direct correction.

One pattern worth noticing: Andre's difficulties cluster almost entirely on structures where Chinese carries meaning through **word order and position** and English has no equivalent ordering — complements of every kind (descriptive complement, duration complement, potential complement), prepositional phrases placed **before** the verb, and the position of time expressions. Anything that maps straight onto English word order (basic 比 comparisons, simple 了) he picks up quickly and needs little time on; everything else needs repeated word-order drilling. Explaining the rule does not work on its own — he has to produce large quantities of it out loud.

2. Grammar Difficulties and Typical Errors

Grammar point	Typical error (his own sentences)	Correct version	Suggested drill
Telling 的 / 得 / 地 apart	他说汉语得很好。 她高兴的说。	他汉语说得很好。 她高兴地说。 (他说的汉语很好听。)	Rapid three-way sorting: you read a sentence, he says which "de" it takes
Descriptive complement (V得) + verb copying (separable verbs)	他唱歌得很好。	他唱歌唱得很好。 他歌唱得很好。	Substitution using 唱歌, 说话, 游泳, 跑步, 做饭
Position of the duration complement	我学中文一年。	我学中文了一年。 我学了一年中文。	Ask 多长时间; he must answer in a complete sentence
Word order in time expressions: 两个月前 vs 前两个月	Uses 前两个月 as though it meant 两个月前; 两个星期我要去中国之后。	两个月前我开始学第3册。(a point in time) 前两个月我工作很忙。(a stretch of time) 最近两个月 / 两个星期之后	Draw a timeline; say the phrase, he points to the position and builds a sentence
比 comparison (II): degree of difference	他比我很高。 我不比他高。(meaning 没有...那么...)	他比我更高。 / 他比我高多了。 他比我高一点儿 / 高得多。 我没有他 (那么) 高。	Compare two people, two cities, two restaurants — three sentences each time
Prepositional phrases before the verb: 离, 从, 往, 对, 给	我家很近超市。 我说汉语对老师。 我打电话给我妈妈每天。	我家离超市很近。 我对老师说汉语。 我每天给我妈妈打电话。 从我家往东走。	Say a sentence built on English word order and have him reorder it; also route-giving
The 是...的 construction (emphasis)	我去年开始学汉语的。 Or drops it where emphasis is needed, saying only 我去年开始学汉语	我是去年开始学汉语的。 我是坐飞机来的。 我是在大学学的。	Ask about real experience: when / where / how / with whom
了 / 着 / 过, 还没...呢, 刚 / 刚才, 不 / 没	我昨天不去。 我刚才回家了, 现在很累。	我昨天没去。 我刚回家, 现在很累。 / 刚才我在做饭。 你吃早饭了吗? ——我还没吃呢。	Question-and-answer drill; turn affirmative sentences into past negatives

Total negation with 一...也/都: 一 + measure word + noun + 也/都 + 不/没	我没有一个朋友在这儿。 昨天我什么都不吃。	我在这儿一个朋友也没有。 昨天我什么都没吃。 这个月我一次电影也没看。	Exaggeration chain: 今天我 一...也没...
当 / 成为; the measure words 名 and 个	我想成为老师。 (in casual speech) 我们学校有三十个老师。	我想当老师。(当 + occupation, the normal spoken choice) 他后来成为了一名有名的医生。(成 为 for a resulting change) 我们学校有二十名老师。	Occupation substitution: 当 医生 / 当老师 / 一名学生

3. Suggested Classroom Drills

The three points below give the best return on time (once one word-order problem is solved, the others tend to come with it). Each runs Lead-in → Drill → Extension, and all of it works in a one-to-one online lesson, with no group or pair activities needed. The teacher's lines can be used exactly as written.

Drill 1 Descriptive complement (V得) + verb copying (also practises 的/得/地)

Lead-in (start from his real life)

Teacher: 你周末常常做什么?

Student: 我常常唱歌。

Teacher: 你唱歌唱得怎么样?

Student: 我唱歌唱得还可以。(If he drops the second 唱, simply repeat the question — do not supply the answer.)

Drill (substitution: you give only the verb-object phrase, he has to repeat the verb)

Teacher: 说汉语。 Student: 我说汉语说得不太好。

Teacher: 做饭。 Student: 我做饭做得很好吃。

Teacher: 游泳、跑步、打篮球、写汉字..... (fast pace, ten or more)

Extension (talk about other people, revising 比 comparison along the way)

Teacher: 你朋友唱歌唱得怎么样?

Student: 他唱歌唱得非常好, 比我好多了。

Error correction (say a wrong sentence on purpose; he corrects it and explains why)

Teacher: 他唱歌得很好。 Student: 应该说"他唱歌唱得很好"。

Teacher: 她高兴的说。 Student: 应该用"地": 她高兴地说。

Drill 2 Duration complement and the position of time expressions

Lead-in

Teacher: 你学中文学了多长时间了?

Student: 我学中文学了两年了。

Drill (you give an action plus a length of time; he produces both word orders)

Teacher: 坐公共汽车, 半个小时。

Student: 我坐公共汽车坐了半个小时。 / 我坐了半个小时公共汽车。

Teacher: 游泳, 一个小时; 看电视, 四十分钟; 等你, 二十分钟.....

Extension + error correction

Teacher: 说说你的周末, 一定要用三个时段。

Teacher: (deliberate mistake) 我学中文一年。 Student: 我学中文学了一年。

Teacher: "两个月前"和"前两个月"有什么不一样? 请各说一句。

Drill 3 The 是...的 construction (he has asked for extra practice on this)

Lead-in (ask about real experiences — the answers naturally call for 是...的)

Teacher: 你是什么时候开始学汉语的? Student: 我是两年前开始学的。

Teacher: 你是在哪儿学的? Student: 我是在网上学的。

Teacher: 你昨天是怎么回家的? Student: 我是走回来的。

Drill (transformation: turn a plain statement about a past event into an emphatic one)

Teacher: 他昨天来了。(emphasise the time) Student: 他是昨天来的。

Teacher: 我在北京买了这本书。(emphasise the place) Student: 我是在北京买的。

Extension (reverse the roles — he asks, you answer truthfully; this drills the question form)

Teacher: 现在你用"是...的"问我三个问题。

All-purpose transformation drill (usable in every lesson, 2–3 minutes): give one base sentence and have him transform it four times in a row.

Base sentence: 我今天去图书馆。 → ① negative, past: 我昨天没去图书馆。 → ② total negation: 这个星期我一次图书馆也没去。 → ③ comparison: 我跑步跑得没有他那么快。 → ④ emphasis: 我是跟朋友一起去的。

4. Listening and Speaking Practice

- **Dictation:** 3–5 sentences per lesson, each one containing that lesson's target structure (e.g. 我打篮球打了一个小时). Once he has written them, check **word order** rather than the characters.
- **Retelling:** tell a short story of 80–120 characters using HSK 1–3 vocabulary and have him retell it, using at least two target structures. Tell it twice at first, then work down to once.
- **Shadowing:** use the audio for the Book 3 texts he already owns, 1–2 minutes per lesson, focusing on sentence rhythm, pausing and neutral tone.
- **Picture description:** share a picture on screen and have him produce five sentences, specifying structures that must appear (e.g. ...着..., 比...多了, 越来越...).
- **A standing slot, "My week":** every lesson, have him describe his actual past week — work, study, what he did at the weekend — using that lesson's target structures.
- **Communicative tasks:** set up a realistic situation so the target structure appears naturally — asking you for time off, a visit to the doctor, asking directions, comparing two restaurants, talking about weekend plans. During free conversation, note his errors on the side and correct them together at the end, so you are not breaking into what he is saying.
- **Pronunciation work should focus on tones:** third-tone sandhi in sequences, the — / 不 tone changes, and telling second tone from third. Common problems for English speakers are a fourth tone that is not short and sharp enough, a habitual rise at the end of a sentence, and stressing every syllable in a multi-syllable word. Please model these directly and have him repeat until he gets them right.

5. Correction Preferences and Pacing

The activities above are only suggestions — how you run the lesson is entirely your call. The points below are the student's own stated preferences.

- **Correct him directly.** He explicitly welcomes clear correction; there is no need to soften it. Errors on the target structure should be interrupted and corrected **on the spot**; note other small errors down and deal with them at the end of the lesson so his fluency is not broken up.
- **Give him a chance to self-correct first:** repeat his sentence and stop at the point of the error ("他唱歌.....? "). If he cannot fix it, give him the correct sentence, then have him say the **whole sentence** again.
- **Do not accept one-word answers.** (Teacher: 你昨天去哪儿了? Student: 图书馆。 Teacher: 请说完整的句子。 Student: 我昨天去图书馆了。) This is the push he most needs at the moment.
- **Textbook pacing:** carry on from Book 3 Lesson 4 (又...又..., V着V, 了 marking change, 越来越...), then Lesson 5 (potential complement, 刚 / 刚才). When you reach the potential complement, go back and contrast it with the descriptive complement — 跳得很好 / 跳得了 / 跳不了 (*does it well / can manage it / can't manage it*) — presenting the three forms together will make it click faster.
- **Cyclical review:** spend 5–10 minutes each lesson returning to one or two of the older problems in the table above (especially 的/得/地, the duration complement and preposition placement), rather than waiting until he has forgotten them.
- It would be worth keeping a shared document logging his typical errors from each lesson and reviewing it every couple of weeks, so he can see which errors have stopped appearing — that kind of measurable feedback does a lot for motivation.